ceasefire and have some of the bodies exhumed. All the remains had decomposed by then, but from Avasthy's pocket Kukrety recovered a letter written to his wife and a piece of paper with a prayer written on it.

48 BRIGADE (BOMDILA)

Lieutenant Colonel Jai Singh's decision to pull his battalion (5 Guards) out of the fray after the Thembang Battle on the evening of 17 November and the fiasco of sending out a column the next day reduced the battle of Bomdila into a non-event. In the annals of Indian warfare, time and again battles that were being won turned on their head whenever the king was killed. None of the Indian commanders in NEFA—be it Nam Ka Chu, Dirang Dzong or Bomdila—seemed to realize that their departure from the battlefield, whatever the reason, would result in pandemonium. In Brigadier Gurbax Singh's defence, it must be acknowledged that he did try and hold his ground at Thembang on 17 November and then received orders from Kaul which undermined whatever little chance he had of fighting a defensive battle.

The Chinese 33 Regiment had followed the 419 Division across Poshing-la and after Thembang had been taken, their 3rd Battalion had begun probing towards Bomdila in small parties. One column crossed the river and headed for the Manda-la Ridge. The Chinese were expecting Bomdila to be heavily fortified and their other infiltrating groups began to occupy the immediate heights around the town.

As had been the case with Dirang Dzong, the defences of Bomdila were ad hoc, with little or no deployment of barbed wire and mines despite there being no shortage of supplies. It was almost as if the commanders of both these garrisons had lulled themselves into believing that the Chinese would never come this far, convinced that the Tawang Chu would be the dividing line between Indian and Chinese forces.

Once again, official Indian records paint a slightly different picture, giving 1 Sikh LI a generous cop-out by describing in detail the systematic fallback of the mobile column to its forward defences in the face of 'massive Chinese attacks'. This is not only contradicted by the Chinese version of events, the remaining officers in Bomdila have vividly described the situation on the ground where the Sikh LI troops were caught out in the open, the Chinese having got between them and their original defences at Bomdila. Official history would have us believe that the Sikh LI troops had